

EXCEL CLUSTERED COLUMN CHART

08

Compare multiple series side by side

WHEN TO USE

- Data has **categories** and **2-3 measures** to compare (e.g., Actual vs Target).
- Answers: **Which series is higher in each category?**
- Use it for **performance vs goal**, this year vs last year, or group comparisons.

BUSINESS QUESTION

- Which regions met their sales target?
- How far above or below target is each region?
- Which region missed its target the most?

DATA EXAMPLE

	A	B	C
1	Region	Target	Actual
2	North	100	112
3	South	90	78
4	East	80	85
5	West	70	64

DATA ANALYST USE CASE

Example: **Target Tracking**

QUESTION

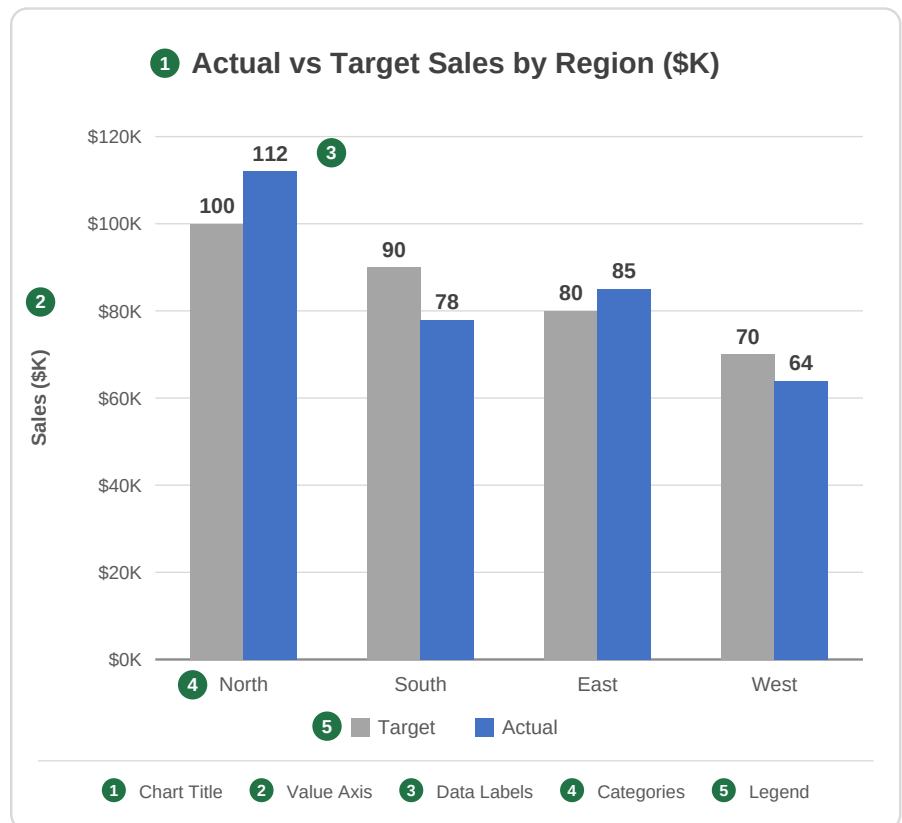
Did each region hit its target?

CHART

Clustered Column Chart

INSIGHT

North (+12%) and East (+6%) beat target; South (-13%) and West (-9%) fell short.



HOW TO CREATE IT IN EXCEL



- 1** Select all the data, including the headers (A1:C5).
- 2** Go to the **Insert** tab and open the **Charts** group.
- 3** Click **Insert Column or Bar Chart** > **2-D Column** > **Clustered Column**.
- 4** Add a clear **Chart Title** and keep the legend so readers know Target from Actual.
- 5** **Format**: use grey for Target, a strong colour for Actual, and add Data Labels.

DO / DON'T

DO ✓

- ✓ Limit to 2-3 series per category
- ✓ Use grey for Target, colour for Actual
- ✓ Keep the series order consistent
- ✓ Add a legend or direct labels

DON'T ✗

- ✗ Add too many series
- ✗ Use similar-looking colours
- ✗ Cram in more than 6 categories
- ✗ Mix up which series is which

DATA ANALYST TIP



Use it when comparing two or three measures within each category.

More than three series? Try a line chart, or split it into separate charts.